

Module 5

Categorical Imperative and Utilitarianism



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Categorical Imperative & Utilitarianism

OBJECTIVES

At the end of the lesson, the learners are expected to:

1. Analyze crucial differences between rights, responsibilities, and duties.
2. Evaluate the value of duty to Kant.
3. Explain why universal values are necessary for human survival.



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Subtopic 1

Kant's Categorical Imperative



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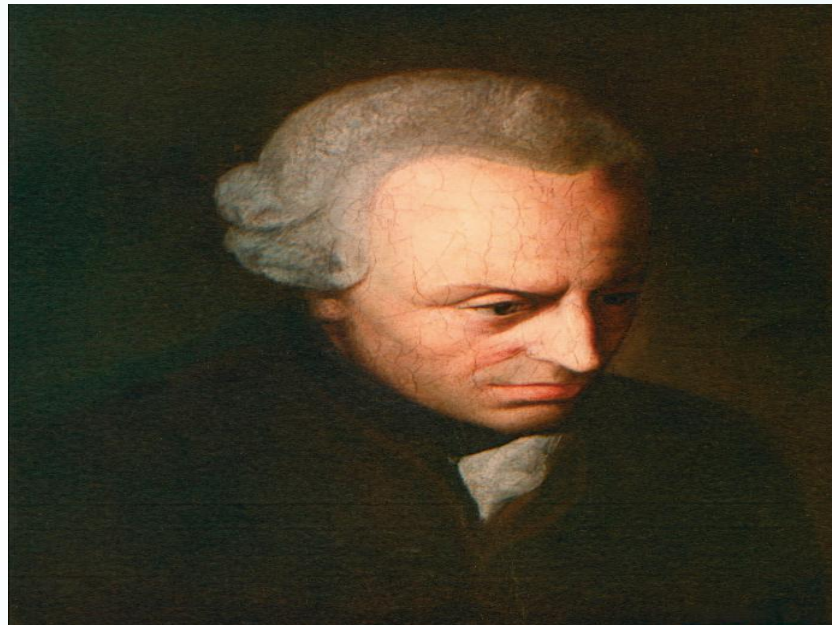
LIFE OF IMMANUEL KANT

1724-1804

He was an influential **German philosopher** in the Age of Enlightenment. He was also an important enlightenment figure in the history of racism, because of his brief but very accurate commentary on Pure Reason.



Born in 1724 in Königsberg, now part of Russia, to a harness-maker of modest means. As a boy, Kant was sent to a Pietist school for his early education. At sixteen, he enrolled in the University of Königsberg, also known as the Albertina, where he became interested in philosophy.



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WHAT IS DEONTOLOGY?

Deontology refers to "obligation, duty", which is the normative ethical position that judges the morality of an action based on rules. Because rules "bind you to your duty".

Deontological Theory: Also known as “Duty Ethics,” as Kantianism focuses on **duty** rather than **consequences**.



Deontology

- ❑ Theory of duty or moral obligation
 - Duty
 - Role-related duty
 - General duty

Obligation:

Requirements set on a person because of his/her identity



Deontology vs Utilitarianism



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KANTIAN ETHICS

Deontological Theory

For any action to have any moral worth, we can only look at the motives or intentions behind the act.

Deontological theories do not list consequences as being important in assessing morality, unlike utilitarian/teleological theories.



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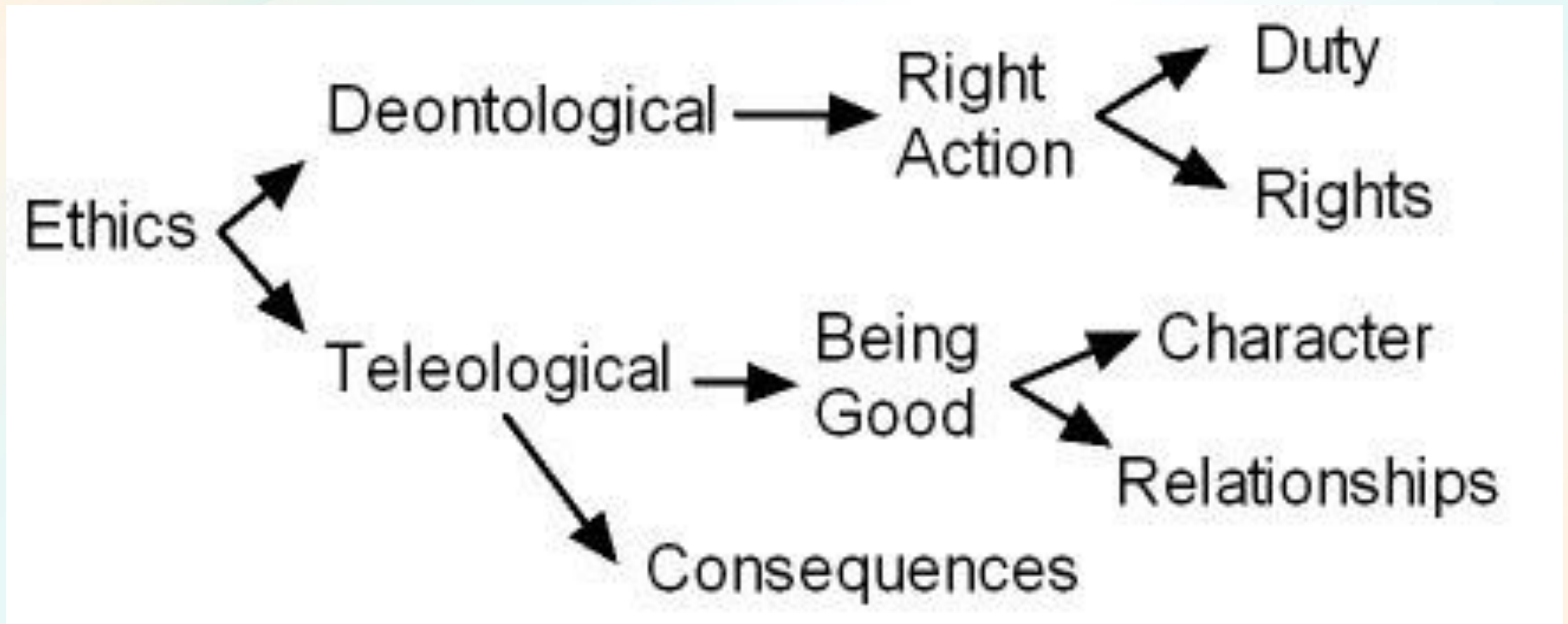
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DIFFERENCE BETWEEN DEONTOLOGY AND UTILITARIANISM



Basic Kantian Themes

1. **Personal autonomy:** The moral person is a rational self-legislator.
2. **Respect:** Persons should always be treated as an end, not a means –‘No persons should be *used*.’
3. **Duty:** The moral action is one that we must do by a certain principle, not because of its good consequences.



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For Deontologists

- ☐ An act is right if it conforms to the relevant moral obligation; and it is wrong if it violates the relevant moral obligation.
- ☐ They argue that the consequences of an action are irrelevant to moral evaluation.
- ☐ They emphasize that the value of an action lies in motive, especially motives of obligation.



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Moral worth

On Kant's view, the moral worth of an action is not determined by its consequences but of:

Good Will
Duty of Ethics



Good Will



- An action has moral worth only when performed by an agent who possesses goodwill (good intention).
- An agent has goodwill only if a moral obligation based on a universally valid norm is the action's sole motive.
- All good moral acts must be grounded in goodwill.
- Goodwill indicates that the act was carried out with the best of intentions.
- Goodwill indicates a good action, not because ultimately the consequences are good but because the intention is good in itself.



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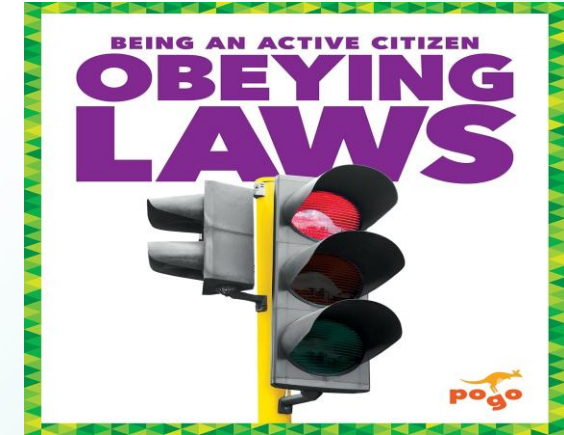


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Practical Application of Deontological Ethics

1. Paying taxes
2. Obeying the law
3. Serving the military
4. Following the 10 commandments for Christians, 5 pillars for Muslim, 8 fold-path for Buddhism



In conclusion,

Kant's ethical reasoning provides a way to inspect and select the principles of our actions as basic to our loves as individuals, organizations, and corporations.

For Kant, the human person is always the end and never a means because of the presence of moral law in him.



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